A Wolf in Sheep's Clothing: Citizen Uncertainty and Democratic Backsliding

Caterina Chiopris, The Harvard Academy for International and Area Studies
Monika Nalepa, University of Chicago
Georg Vanberg, Duke University

A prominent contemporary phenomenon is "backsliding" of democratic countries into (semi-)authoritarian practices. Such episodes often unfold gradually over time in contexts where the ultimate intentions of governments are not clear. We present a model that focuses on the role of such uncertainty in backsliding. In the model, a government engages in a reform that may allow for subsequent actions that are inconsistent with the rule of law. Citizens must decide whether to replace the incumbent following the reform. A central implication of the model is that in a dynamic setting, citizen support for incumbents can give rise to democratic backsliding even if citizens are fundamentally opposed to authoritarianism. An original survey experiment conducted in Poland provides clear support for the model's implications.

Recent years have witnessed a wave of "democratic backsliding," including in countries that appeared to be consolidated democracies (Bermeo 2016; Serra 2012; Waldner and Lust 2018). Poland and Hungary provide vivid examples. Following the collapse of the Soviet bloc, each quickly established a well-functioning democratic regime. By 1999, both had joined NATO and five years later became full-fledged members of the European Union. By all appearances, these countries seemed well-ensconced among Western democracies. And yet, only a decade later, both were governed by parties that were chipping away at democratic institutions and norms, raising the specter of creeping authoritarianism (Jenne and Mudde 2012; Sedelmeier 2014). In long-established democracies as well, including Israel and the United States, recent years have seen significant concerns over developments that may be harbingers of authoritarian backsliding (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018).

A puzzling feature of many of these cases is that considerable evidence suggests that backsliding can occur despite the fact that many citizens—including those who support would-be autocrats—appear to be strongly committed to democratic values. For example, Voeten (2016) shows that citizens in Poland and Hungary display high support for democracy similar to that in established democracies. Similarly, responses for the survey experiment we conducted in Poland during its period of potential backsliding (details below) indicate no difference in democratic values across supporters of the ruling Law and Justice party (PiS) and those who cast their votes for parties in the opposition.[1] This raises a crucial question: How, and under what conditions, can democratic backsliding go hand-in-hand with apparently widespread commitments to democracy?

In this article, we develop an answer by offering a theory of democratic backsliding that highlights how closet autocrats can come to power through regular electoral channels despite popular support for democracy. The key to our argument is that backsliding is a dynamic process that typically involves uncertainty about the ultimate intentions of incumbent

Caterina Chiopris (chiopris@g.harvard.edu) is an Academy Scholar at The Harvard Academy for International and Area Studies, 1727 Cambridge Street, room E106, Cambridge, MA 02138. Monika Nalepa (mnalepa@uchicago.edu) is a professor of political science and political economy at the University of Chicago, Pick 324A 5838 S. University Avenue, Chicago IL, 60637. Georg Vanberg (georg.vanberg@duke.edu) is Ernestine Friedl Distinguished Professor in the Department of Political Science, 140 Science Drive, 219 Gross Hall, Duke University, Durham, NC 27708.

Monika Nalepa is grateful for funding from the Pozen Center for Human Rights and the Center for International Social Science at the University of Chicago. Replication files are available in the *JOP* Dataverse (https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/jop). The empirical analysis has been successfully replicated by the *JOP* replication analyst. An online appendix with supplementary material is available at https://doi.org/10.1086/734253.

1. Of course, as Svolik (2020) notes, survey responses may not be reliable indicators of true support for democracy. Nevertheless, these results suggest that backsliding does not necessarily go hand-in-hand with low attachments to democracy.

Published online June 4, 2025.

The Journal of Politics, volume 87, number 4, October 2025. © 2025 Southern Political Science Association. All rights reserved. Published by The University of Chicago Press for the Southern Political Science Association. https://doi.org/10.1086/734253

governments. Incumbents with authoritarian aspirations rarely pursue their designs openly or all at once. Instead, authoritarianism proceeds incrementally. Piecemeal institutional reforms that typically appear consistent with democratic commitments are used to lay the groundwork for future authoritarian power grabs (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018).

These dynamics are critical because they generate uncertainty among observers and citizens about motivations and goals: Is the incumbent a "wolf in sheep's clothing" who poses a threat to democracy, or is he committed to the democratic order and has legitimate (or at least defensible) reasons for the reforms? Consider the Polish and Hungarian cases again. The PiS and Fidesz governments adamantly deny that the reforms they undertook were designed to undermine democracy. Instead, both argued that the aim was to reduce the residual influence of the former communist regime.

Currently, the Netanyahu government in Israel insists that its judicial reforms (which restrict the power of judges but not of prosecutors) are an attempt to enhance democratic accountability, rather than pave the way—as many critics fear—for attacks on democracy. Such uncertainty leaves voters who are committed to democracy but are sympathetic to the stated justifications for reforms in a quandary: The most direct defense against a closet autocrat is to remove the incumbent from power before authoritarianism has advanced too far. But if the incumbent is not a closet autocrat, and truly pursues reform for the publicly stated reasons that the voter finds appealing, removing him would be a mistake. This uncertainty takes center stage in our model.

The model demonstrates that under certain conditions, even if citizens are fundamentally opposed to authoritarianism, the dynamic nature of democratic backsliding allows a strategic closet autocrat to establish a hold on power by playing the "wolf in sheep's clothing." The conditions that give rise to such a scenario depend on three factors: how ideologically extreme citizen preferences are, the degree of uncertainty facing voters about the ultimate intentions that motivate incumbent behavior, and the depth of voters' democratic attachments. An original survey experiment we conducted in Poland in the spring of 2022 provides significant empirical support for the central causal mechanism laid out in the model.

The analysis has a number of substantive implications. Perhaps the most important is that democratic backsliding becomes more likely as citizen preferences become ideologically more extreme but that the level of extremity required depends on voter uncertainty about incumbent intentions: When citizens are reasonably confident that incumbents are not closet autocrats, backsliding becomes possible even if citizens hold relatively moderate views. As we discuss in the conclusion, this suggests that democratic backsliding can pose a particular risk in "consolidated" democracies, and it also offers an additional rationale for the well-known observation that moments of crisis are especially prone to democratic breakdown.

The argument and evidence we present contribute to the rich and growing literature on democratic backsliding. One strand of this literature, including influential work by Luo and Przeworski (2023); Helmke, Kroeger, and Paine (2022); and Gratton and Lee (2023) focuses on attempts by incumbents to "tilt the playing field" by engaging in institutional manipulations that undermine the integrity of elections. This is clearly a plausible mechanism of backsliding. In contrast, our argument assumes that initial authoritarian power grabs do not directly boost the incumbent's electoral prospects. Doing so allows us to focus on how citizen uncertainty, and the manipulation of such uncertainty by would-be autocrats, influences democratic backsliding. Our work also connects to seminal contributions by Svolik (2020), who highlights the significance of polarization and political culture. In his account, as polarization grows, citizens become willing to trade perceived ideological gains for adherence to democratic norms and institutions. A slide into authoritarianism is the price citizens are willingly pay to secure policies they favor (see also Graham and Svolik 2020; Jang, Milačić, and Svolik 2023). In contrast, our model focuses on the uncertainty confronting citizens, which can lead to backsliding even if citizens would not knowingly support an autocrat. As a consequence, under the logic we lay out, citizens can come to regret their electoral choices ex post (when they discover that they have empowered an autocrat)—a result that is not possible when citizens willingly embrace authoritarianism to secure ideological advantage. Finally, Grillo and Prato (2023) also examine the gradual process of backsliding in the face of citizen uncertainty over incumbent intentions. But they offer a logic that is distinct from ours. Rather than playing a "wolf in sheep's clothing," in Grillo's and Prato's model, incumbents openly challenge democratic norms and then backpedal, hoping that by doing so, they can mislead citizens about their democratic commitments.

A THEORY OF DEMOCRATIC BACKSLIDING

Our argument is designed to capture two key features. First, democratic backsliding is a dynamic process that unfolds over time. Initial steps toward authoritarian power grabs are rarely explicit. Instead, governments with authoritarian aspirations typically pursue initial institutional reforms that enable subsequent authoritarian moves. For example, they may reform judicial institutions to loosen judicial oversight. They might amend media law to reduce journalistic scrutiny. They may alter electoral institutions to reduce effective

political competition. Having secured such changes, governments are in position to more easily advance an authoritarian agenda, for example, by sidelining political opponents. This dynamic aspect leads to the second key feature: citizen uncertainty over incumbent motivations. Generally, governments do not acknowledge autocratic goals in initiating such institutional reforms. Instead, they claim a commitment to democratic values. They defend reforms as an effort to make "ordinary" political decision-making easier. Such arguments may appear plausible: For example, reorganization of the judiciary may be a way for a new democracy to extricate itself from the influence of judges with ties to a prior authoritarian regime. Reforms of media law may be directed at protecting the privacy of citizens. Changes to the electoral system may be guided by the goal of making politicians more accountable to voters.

To capture these aspects, we employ a two period, incomplete information model with three players: a representative citizen, two types of incumbents, and an opposition. The two period setup allows us to model, in the simplest way possible, the dynamic aspect of the process we are considering. In the first period, an incumbent government chooses an institutional reform that affects the actions available to it in the second period. The key feature of backsliding we want to examine is that citizens confront uncertainty regarding the intentions behind an institutional reform. The reform may be motivated by ordinary (and acceptable) ideological goals or by a desire to open the door to authoritarian actions. This uncertainty creates a potential dilemma: Citizens who are ideologically sympathetic to the "ordinary" policy goals of an incumbent (say, restricting abortion access or limiting the influence of "holdover" communist judges) may nonetheless be concerned about constraining a closet autocrat (say, preventing incumbents from using the judiciary to restrict political competition, prosecute political rivals, etc.).

We represent this uncertainty through two modeling choices. First, we assume that in the second period, governments can take actions in two separate domains. The first are "ordinary" policy decisions, that is, choices that are acknowledged by all players as falling within the scope of acceptable democratic decision-making (though of course citizens can have ideological conflict over these). The second is an "authoritarian" dimension, that is, actions that are deemed undesirable by all citizens, regardless of ideological position. (In other words, this authoritarian dimension is a "valence" dimension [Stokes 1963].)

Critically, the first-period institutional reform affects the maneuver room for the government in both domains: Loosening judicial scrutiny, for example, may make it easier to pursue ideological policy goals (say, restricting abortion access), but it may also make it easier to act in an autocratic fashion (e.g., through politically motivated prosecutions of political competitors). Specifically, the first-period incumbent chooses an institutional reform $i \in [0, 1]$. In the second period, the government chooses a policy $p \in [0, 1]$ in the ordinary policy dimension. In addition, it takes a position on the authoritarian dimension $a \in [0, 1]$. In other words, the second period is defined by a two-dimensional "action space," $A \equiv [0, i] \times [0, i]$, in which the government chooses $(p, a) \in A$.

The second modeling choice that allows us to capture citizen uncertainty is the assumption that there are two types of incumbents. The ideological incumbent is purely policy motivated and has no interest in authoritarian action. The ideal point of this incumbent is given by $X_I = (1, 0)$. In words, the ideologue favors policy one but has no desire to take authoritarian action. The second type of incumbent is a closet autocrat whose ideal point is given by $X_{CA} = (1, 1)$. In words, the closet autocrat has the same preferences as the ideologue in the policy dimension but also wants to move in an autocratic direction. Putting it differently, the citizen knows where the incumbent stands ideologically but is uncertain about his authoritarian intentions. The citizen's ex ante belief that the incumbent is a closet autocrat is given by $Pr(\text{Closet Autocrat}) = \alpha \in (0, 1)$. The citizen faces an electoral choice between the incumbent (over whose type she is uncertain) and a challenger whose ideal point is given by $x_O = (0, 0)$. This means the challenger is ideologically to the left of the incumbent and is not interested in authoritarian actions. Figure 1 provides an illustration.

The citizen's ideal point is given by $X_C = (x_C, 0)$, where $x_C \in (0, 1)$. This implies that the citizen is purely policy motivated: She favors institutional reforms in so far as they are instrumental to her preferred policies, but she dislikes autocratic actions.[2] Specifically, the citizen's preferences over the government's second-period actions are given by

$$U_C((p, a)) = -(p - x_C)^2 - \beta a^2, \tag{1}$$

where β captures the intensity of the citizen's opposition to authoritarian moves. Because we are interested in democratic backsliding when citizens are intrinsically opposed to authoritarianism, we assume that $\beta \geq 1$, which ensures that the citizen always prefers the opposition to the closet autocrat if

2. The assumption that the opposition's ideal point is at (0,0) is without loss of generality; allowing the opposition to be less moderate, that is, moving its policy ideal point below 0 can only exacerbate the threat of democratic backsliding. Similarly, the assumption that the ideologue and the closet autocrat share the same ideal point in the policy dimension is not necessary; see the appendix for a more general version in which we allow the ideological preferences of the two types of incumbents to diverge.

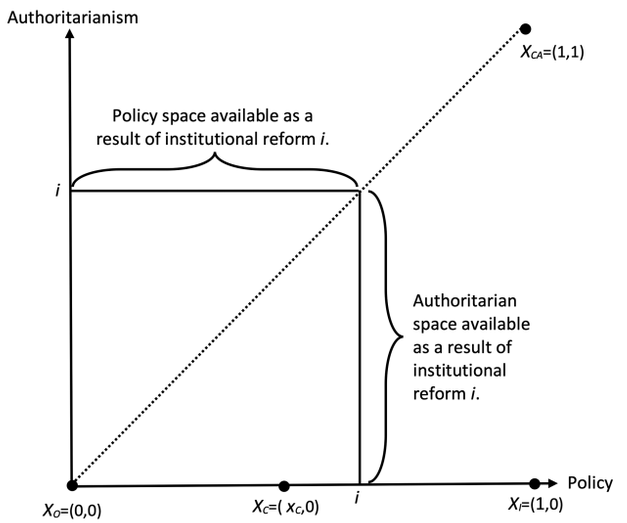

Figure 1. Determination of the policy space as a result of first.

both could implement their ideal points (even if the citizen's ideal point approaches [1,0]).[3]

The final element of the model concerns the preferences of politicians, that is, the incumbent and the opposition. We assume that these actors are motivated by three concerns. First, they place a value $b \geq 0$ on being in office. Second, they have instrumental outcome concerns: They would prefer second-period outcomes (both in terms of policy and authoritarianism) to be as close as possible to their ideal point. Finally, they have expressive preferences: They prefer to publicly support policies that are close to their actual preferences. Substantively, one way to think about these expressive preferences is in terms of "branding": Parties represent a set of policies they are committed to and that form the basis of their appeal. All things being equal, they prefer to announce or back policies that are consistent with these underlying commitments and dislike those that require them to compromise the party's brand (Lupu 2014). Such expressive preferences may be sincere (politicians prefer to act in ways that are consistent with their convictions) or instrumental (building and maintaining a support base for the party requires some consistency between the party's rhetoric and actions; Aldrich and Rohde 2000). The Polish PiS and Hungarian FiDesz parties' behavior during the early 2000s provides an illustration: Instead of compromising to make themselves politically viable, they stayed in opposition to preserve their antiliberal brand.

Putting these elements together, the payoffs for the incumbent depend critically on whether he is reelected to a second term. Consider an incumbent who implements reform i but is not reelected. Letting $(\hat{p}, \hat{a})$ denote the second-period policy chosen by the (new) government, we assume that the payoffs of the ideologue and closet autocrat are given by an additive function of standard quadratic loss across the ideological and authoritarian dimensions:

$$U_I((\hat{p}, \hat{a})) = -((\hat{p} - 1)^2 + \hat{a}^2), \tag{2}$$

$$U_{CA}((\hat{p}, \hat{a})) = -((\hat{p} - 1)^2 + (\hat{a} - 1)^2). \tag{3}$$

In contrast, if the incumbent is reelected and implements policy (p, a), she secures the office benefit but must also incur the expressive costs of implementing a policy that may not conform to her ideal point. These payoffs are given by

$$U_I((p, a)) = -((p - 1)^2 + a^2) - \theta((p - 1)^2 + a^2) + b, \tag{4}$$

$$U_{CA}((p, a)) = -((p - 1)^2 + (a - 1)^2) - \theta((p - 1)^2 + (a - 1)^2) + b, \tag{5}$$

where $\theta \geq 0$ is the weight the ideologue attaches to expressive preferences. The first term in the expression captures the outcome concerns, the second the expressive concerns, and the final term the office motivations.

Summarizing, the model is defined by the following sequence of play:

1. Nature chooses the type of incumbent, with $Pr(\text{Closet Autocrat}) = \alpha \in (0, 1)$.
2. Period 1: The incumbent government chooses an institutional reform $i_j \in [0, 1]$, where $j \in \{I, CA\}$.
3. Period 2: The citizen updates beliefs about the type of the incumbent and either reelects the incumbent or replaces him with the opposition.
4. Period 2: The second-period government chooses an action $(p, a)_j \in [0, i] \times [0, i]$, where $j \in \{I, CA\}$, consisting of a choice in the policy dimension and a move on the authoritarian dimension.
5. The game ends, and payoffs are collected.

A suitable solution concept is Perfect Bayesian Equilibrium, which requires that players' strategies are sequentially rational and that they update their beliefs in accordance with Bayes' rule along the equilibrium path. We reserve a full statement of equilibria and proofs to the formal appendix. Here, we focus on presenting the intuition and substantive implications underlying the equilibria.

3. This differentiates our approach from Svolik's (2020) model, in which citizens vote for the autocrat because the ideological profile of the opposition is not acceptable to them.

Analysis

To understand the intuition underlying the model's equilibria, and its implications for democratic backsliding, it is useful to begin by considering the core logic confronting the key players: the two types of incumbents and the representative citizen. We begin with the citizen's electoral decision. From the citizen's point of view, the incumbent's first-period institutional reform is significant for two different reasons. Most obviously, it defines the government's maneuver room in the second period. As such, there are two countervailing considerations. On the one hand, the reform can open up room for second-period governments to implement policies the citizen favors. On the other hand, the reform can also enable authoritarian actions, which the citizen opposes. Put differently, the citizen may be sympathetic to reforms to the extent that these reforms will allow for ordinary policy choices she agrees with. But she may also be concerned that the same reforms remove checks on incumbents who turn out to be closet autocrats. However, the implications of reforms for second-period policymaking are only one consideration. A second is that reform can act as a signal of whether the incumbent has autocratic goals or not.

As a result, the representative citizen's strategy is characterized by a threshold that makes the electoral decision contingent on the citizen's (updated) beliefs about incumbent type and the extent of the institutional reform that has been adopted. Suppose, for example, that the citizen—having observed the first-period institutional reform—has become convinced that the incumbent is an ideologue and will not exploit the reforms to engage in an authoritarian move. In this case, the citizen's reelection decision reduces to a straightforward ideological choice: She reelects the incumbent if the incumbent's reform implies a second-period policy that is closer to her ideal point than the opposition. As is intuitive, this threshold is given by $T_I = 2x_C$. We illustrate this threshold in figure 2, which maps out the citizen's strategy.

Suppose that—following the first-period institutional choice—the citizen believes that the incumbent is a closet autocrat. This knowledge puts the citizen in a quandary: On the one hand, the policy choice of the closet autocrat may be ideologically more palatable than the alternative offered by the opposition. On the other hand, the citizen is opposed to the fact that the closet autocrat will also exploit the maneuver room created by the institutional reform to engage in authoritarian power grabs. The citizen resolves this tension by adopting a strategy under which she will reelect a known closet autocrat only if the autocrat chooses a first-period institutional reform that sufficiently constrains future authoritarian moves. This threshold is given by $T_{CA} = \frac{2x_C}{\beta+1}$. Significantly—as illustrated in figure 2—this threshold is to the left

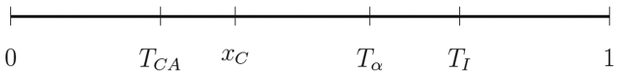

Figure 2. Illustration of citizen threshold strategy.

of the citizen's own ideal point: The citizen is trading ideological proximity for constraints on future authoritarianism. Consequently, the threshold depends on β, the degree to which the citizen is concerned about authoritarian power grabs. As this concern looms larger (β increases), T_{CA} shifts left, implying that the citizen requires tighter constraints on future behavior before she is willing to reelect a known closet autocrat.[4]

Finally, suppose that the citizen remains uncertain about the incumbent's type, that is, the incumbent's authoritarian leanings, after the institutional reform. Once again, there is a threshold ($T_\alpha = \frac{2x_C}{\alpha\beta+1}$ in fig. 2) such that the citizen reelects the incumbent only if the first-period reform falls below it. Intuitively, T_α is between T_I and T_{CA} and depends critically on the citizen's ex ante belief that the incumbent is a closet autocrat (α) and the degree to which she is concerned to avoid authoritarian power grabs (β). As she becomes more and more certain that the incumbent is likely to be a closet autocrat (α goes to 1), this threshold converges on T_{CA}: The citizen requires more stringent constraints on the incumbent to limit potential authoritarian actions in the second period. In contrast, as she becomes more convinced that the incumbent is an ideologue (α goes to 0), this threshold converges on T_I. (Note that this implies that T_α may be to the right or left of x_C.)

Given the citizen's reelection strategy, we are now in a position to consider the incumbent's choice of institutional reform in the first period. The key issue confronting the incumbent is that the institutional reform he adopts has two separate effects: It defines the maneuver room the incumbent has in the second period if reelected, but it also affects the citizen's reelection decision. There are clear incentives to be reelected, as office provides intrinsic benefits as well as the

4. This aspect of the model raises an issue that deserves future exploration: In our model, a closet autocrat is constrained by the extent of institutional reform, that is, constitutional constraints are credible in the sense that the second-period government cannot go beyond the reforms initiated in period 1. We believe this is—at least in the short to medium run—a reasonable assumption; having engaged in some reform does not mean that governments are then able to ignore all constraints. On the other hand, having once engaged in institutional reforms that loosen institutional constraints, citizens might obviously be concerned that they are on a "slippery slope" and that a closet autocrat will not be forced to act within the institutional constraints in the future. We reserve an explicit consideration of this issue for future work.

opportunity to make policy (including the possibility of pursuing an autocratic agenda). This implies that there is value in proposing an institutional reform that will result in reelection, even if this reform is not ideal (from the incumbent's point of view). At the same time, there are expressive costs associated with governing in ways that are not in line with the incumbent's preferences. As a result, there is a limit to the incumbent's willingness to adopt an institutional reform that will result in his reelection. When the institutional reform ensuring reelection constrains the second-period policy choice too much, the incumbent prefers to leave office and tolerate the opposition's ascent to power.

These considerations imply that the two types of incumbents also adopt a threshold strategy. For each incumbent, this threshold marks the most modest institutional reform the incumbent is willing to adopt in order to be reelected. Reforms to the left of these thresholds are so constraining as to make returning to power sufficiently unattractive for the incumbent to choose his ideal point instead. These thresholds are summarized in table 1 (along with the thresholds imposed by the citizen). Figure 3 provides a graphical illustration, where R_{CA} denotes the threshold for the closet autocrat and R_I denotes the threshold for the ideologue. Note that $R_{CA} > R_I$. This is a critical feature that plays a key role in the equilibria. The intuition behind this ordering should be clear: For the closet autocrat, institutional constraints on power are more costly than for the ideologue, as the closet autocrat is constrained in two dimensions rather than just one. As a result, the closet autocrat is quicker to bristle at an institutional constraint. This implies that the institutional commitments incumbents make in the first period can potentially serve as a (costly) signal of their type.

Equilibria

The model's five equilibria, which are unique for any combination of parameters, depend on the relative position of the thresholds that characterize the citizen's and the incumbents' strategies. The equilibria are described in the appendix.[5] Here, it is useful to graph the location of these equilibria in the parameter space. We do so in figure 4, which shows where each equilibrium type occurs as a function of the citizen's ideal point, x_C (plotted on the x-axis), and the citizen's (ex ante) belief about the type of incumbent, α (plotted on the y-axis). The solid lines partition the parameter space into pooling equilibria where neither type is reelected, separating equilibria, and pooling equilibria where both types are reelected. The dashed lines partition further each of the equilibrium categories into areas defined by the first-period equilibrium actions of the incumbent. In areas III and IV, consistent with the logic of separating equilibria, the two types of incumbents choose different institutional reforms. This allows the citizen to learn the type of incumbent she is facing. There are three pooling equilibria (areas I, II, and V). There, both types of incumbents adopt the same institutional reform, which implies that the citizen remains uncertain about the incumbent's intentions. In two of these equilibria (areas I and II), the citizen nevertheless reelects the incumbent. In the third (area V), the citizen replaces the incumbent with the challenger.

Analyzing the space from the point of view of the citizen, consider first the triangular area I in the southeastern part of figure 4. Here, the citizen is ex ante confident (as indicated by α close to 0) that the incumbent is likely to be an ideologue. Moreover, the citizen is ideologically distant from the challenger. As a result, the citizen's desire to give the ideological incumbent sufficient policy leeway outweighs the concern to constrain a potential closet autocrat. The citizen is therefore willing to reelect the incumbent even if the first-period institutional reform is extreme (that is, $i_I = i_{CA} = 1$). Consequently, both types of incumbents adopt that reform.

Consider next what happens if either the citizen is ideologically more moderate, or if the citizen's ex ante belief that the incumbent is a closet autocrat increases. This means that we move up or to the left in the figure into area II. Because the citizen is now concerned about the higher risk of a closet autocrat, she is no longer willing to reelect following an extreme institutional reform: In order to be reelected, the incumbent must adopt a limited institutional reform ($i = T_\alpha$) that provides some insurance in case the incumbent is a closet autocrat. Yet given the proximity of the citizen's and ideologue's ideal points, the "institutional assurance" the citizen requires to support the incumbent leaves the closet autocrat enough room for maneuver to offer this assurance. Consequently, the two incumbent types adopt the same institutional reform ($i = T_\alpha$), and the citizen reelects the incumbent.

As the citizen becomes ideologically even more moderate, we move into equilibrium areas III and IV. Because the citizen is now centrist, satisfying her policy preferences no longer requires far-reaching institutional reforms. Consequently, the risk of authoritarian backsliding enabled by far-reaching institutional reforms begins to loom large for the citizen. As a result, she will only reelect the incumbent if the first-period reforms are sufficiently modest. The ideological incumbent is willing to respect this constraint and adopts a moderate reform. But for the closet autocrat, the price of playing the "wolf in sheep's clothing" is now too high: He is

5. As detailed in the appendix, we impose several restrictions on off-equilibrium path beliefs that serve to eliminate "nuisance equilibria" that are substantively uninteresting.

Table 1. Summary of Thresholds

Threshold	Imposed By	Explanation
$T_{CA} = \frac{2x_C}{\beta+1}$	Citizen	Citizen will reelect known closet autocrat who sets reforms below this threshold.
$T_I = 2x_C$	Citizen	Citizen will reelect known ideologue who sets reforms below this threshold.
$T_\alpha = \frac{2x_C}{\alpha\beta+1}$	Citizen	If the citizen is uncertain about the incumbent's type, she will reelect an incumbent who sets reforms below this threshold.
$R_{CA} = 1 - \frac{\sqrt{2+b}}{\sqrt{2(1+\theta)}}$	Closet autocrat	Closet autocrat will only set reforms at or above this threshold to get reelected.
$R_I = 1 - \frac{\sqrt{b+1}}{\sqrt{1+\theta}}$	Ideologue	Ideologue will only set reforms at or above this threshold to get reelected.

not willing to display the moderation required to be reelected. The result is that the citizen learns the type of incumbent and she only returns the ideologue to office. (Areas III and IV differ precisely in the first-period reforms that the two types of incumbent adopt.)

Finally, consider equilibrium area V at the left side of the parameter space. Here, the citizen's preferences closely approximate those of the opposition: Voting for the challenger is attractive. To convince the citizen to choose the incumbent instead, the incumbent would have to offer an institutional reform that is so highly constraining and close to the status quo (0) that neither the ideologue nor the closet autocrat are willing to limit themselves in this way. Given the expressive costs of governing within such constraints, both accept the fact that they will lose office.

SUBSTANTIVE IMPLICATIONS

What are the substantive implications of the model for the phenomenon of democratic backsliding? We begin with the impact of ideological extremism, which potentially opens the door to a "wolf in sheep's clothing:"

> **Implication 1.** When citizen preferences are sufficiently extreme, ideological incumbents and closet autocrats adopt the same institutional reform in period 1 and are reelected by the citizen. If the incumbent is a closet autocrat, this leads to democratic backsliding in the second period.

This implication captures the pooling equilibria in the right part of the parameter space (areas I and II). As the citizen becomes ideologically more aligned with the incumbent, two dynamics play out. The first is that replacing the incumbent with the opposition becomes less palatable. Even if there is some possibility that the incumbent is an autocrat, the citizen is more willing to reelect in order to obtain policies that are ideologically proximate. This is the logic highlighted by Svolik (2020). The second dynamic concerns the distinct element of our model: citizen uncertainty about the type of incumbent. As the citizen's preferences shift to the right, so does the citizen's tolerance for radical institutional reform. The consequence is that the cost to the closet autocrat of playing the "wolf in sheep's clothing" declines. Once the citizen is sufficiently far to the right, a strategic closet autocrat is willing to adopt the same institutional reform as the ideologue in order to be reelected—in effect "masquerading" as an ideologue. Given her right-leaning preferences, the citizen—despite her uncertainty about the nature of the incumbent—takes a gamble and chooses to reelect. If the incumbent is a closet

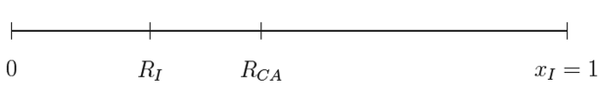

Figure 3. Illustration of incumbent threshold strategy.

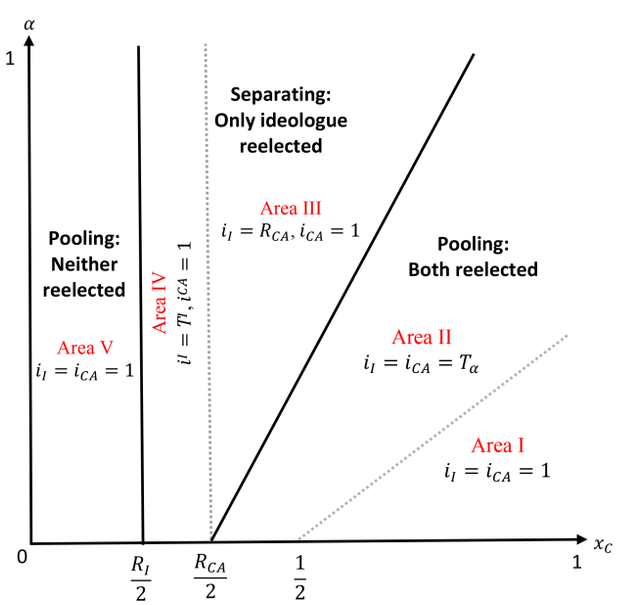

Figure 4. Separating and pooling equilibria as a function of citizen's ideal point, x_c, and citizen's beliefs, α.

autocrat, he will exploit the space created by the institutional reform to take authoritarian actions in period 2. Democratic backsliding occurs.

Critically, in such a scenario, the citizen feels genuine regret ex post. Given the ideological and autocratic policy choices made by the closet autocrat in the second period, she would prefer to "swap out" the closet autocrat for the opposition. But it is now too late. Put differently, unlike in models in which citizens knowingly reelect incumbents because they value ideological payoffs over democratic commitments (Helmke et al. 2022; Howell and Wolton 2018; Svolik 2020), in a dynamic setting characterized by uncertainty, backsliding is possible even when citizens are opposed to authoritarianism—leading to the potential for genuine regret on the part of citizens.

It is useful to contrast this result with the models presented by Grillo and Prato (2023) and Luo and Przeworski (2023). In these accounts, citizen uncertainty about incumbent intentions is also central, but the driver of democratic backsliding is different. The key to these models is that incumbents have the ability to "tilt the playing field" by directly rigging electoral processes to help them maintain power. In contrast, in our model, the closet autocrat cannot directly help himself by tilting the playing field; he must still secure the support of the representative voter. In this sense, our model shows that the ability to manipulate electoral processes is not necessary for backsliding. By making it possible for a "wolf in sheep's clothing" to infiltrate the political system, citizen uncertainty regarding an incumbent's ultimate intentions is sufficient.

Implication 2. When the citizen is (a) less concerned about democratic backsliding ($\delta\beta$ approaches 1) or (b) believes that it is unlikely that she is facing a closet autocrat ($\delta\alpha$ approaches 0), the pooling equilibria become possible, even for more moderate citizen preferences. As a result, democratic backsliding can occur.

This implication highlights that there is an interactive relationship between the ideological extremity of citizen preferences (in terms of the location of x_C relative to x_O) necessary to open the door to democratic backsliding and the degree to which the citizen is concerned about the threat of authoritarianism. As the citizen believes that it is less likely that she is confronting a closet autocrat (α is low), or as she cares less deeply about preventing autocratic moves (β approaches 1), she is more willing to take a gamble on reelecting an incumbent about whose intentions she is uncertain (T_α moves to the right). And as the citizen becomes more willing to reelect incumbents even if they adopt more extreme reforms, strategic closet autocrats perceive an opportunity to masquerade as ideologues by adopting institutional reforms that will allow them to be reelected. In other words, political environments in which citizens believe the threat of authoritarianism is low, or in which citizens have shallow commitments to democratic institutions, are fertile ground for closet autocrats to infiltrate a democratic polity. Such environments invite "wolves in sheep's clothing."

A final implication results from the fact that institutional reforms in the first period serve three distinct purposes: First, they can enlarge the maneuver room for "regular" policymaking in the second period. Second, they serve as a potential signal about the intentions of the incumbent. Finally, they have implications for the extent to which a closet autocrat is constrained in pursuing an authoritarian agenda. One consequence is that if the citizen believes that it is sufficiently likely that the incumbent may be a closet autocrat and she is sufficiently concerned about democratic backsliding, she has incentives to use the decision regarding institutional reforms to "weed out" incumbents she is not willing to support. She will only reelect if the first-period policy reform is so modest that only the ideologue will be willing to implement it. Significantly, this implies that the first-period reform can be below the citizen's ideal point. In this sense, our model endogenously generates a kind of "constitutional culture": The citizen knowingly supports an institutional environment that prevents policymakers from adopting policies she prefers. She does so because "sticking to" this institutional environment is necessary to sideline closet autocrats.

Implication 3. Under some conditions, the citizen enforces limits to institutional reform that will separate the closet autocrat from the ideologue but which also prevent the policymaker from adopting the citizen's preferred policy: The citizen is trading away ideological proximity in order to prevent democratic backsliding.

This last implication depends critically on the interaction between the citizen's (ex ante) belief that she is dealing with a closet autocrat and her concern about preventing democratic backsliding. As the citizen becomes more accepting of authoritarianism (β declines), she is less and less willing to enforce strict limits on first-period institutional reforms—and this is especially the case when the citizen believes that it is unlikely that the incumbent is a closet autocrat. This condition suggests that "consolidated" democratic polities face a potential challenge precisely because of their established democratic traditions: In such circumstances, citizens may be less wary of the motivations of those who compete for political power, which potentially opens the door for closet autocrats to gain a foothold (see implication 2).

AN APPLICATION: DEMOCRATIC BACKSLIDING IN POLAND

The key insight that animates our model is that democratic backsliding is a dynamic process in which closet autocrats—acting like a "wolf in sheep's clothing"—use institutional reforms that appear plausibly democratic to lay the groundwork for future authoritarian actions. The resulting uncertainty surrounding the intentions of incumbents puts citizens in a quandary that may lead to democratic backsliding even if citizens are fundamentally opposed to authoritarianism. Specifically, the model suggests an interactive effect between citizen preferences and their uncertainty about the intentions of incumbents: The degree of ideological extremity required for backsliding depends on how certain citizens are about the incumbent's type. Moreover, with such uncertainty, backsliding can occur even if citizens would not knowingly vote for an authoritarian.

Before we turn to a survey experiment that explores this central feature of our model, we explain the logic of our empirical approach using figure 5. What differentiates the separating and pooling equilibria is how the citizen evaluates the institutional reform pursued by the incumbent. In the separating equilibria, the citizen believes that a far-reaching reform would only be favored by a closet autocrat. If the incumbent pursues a far-reaching reform, she therefore refuses to reelect. In contrast, in the pooling equilibria, the citizen does not think that the reform she has observed is necessarily a sign that the incumbent is a closet autocrat. She believes that the reform may well be "democratic" in the sense that the incumbent is an ideologue with no authoritarian intentions. As a result, she is willing to reelect. Thus, the difference between Citizen A (who reelects following the reform in question) and Citizen B (who does not) is not ideology; they share the same ideal point. Instead, they differ in how they evaluate the reform: Citizen B believes that pursuit of the reform is a clear sign that the incumbent is a closet autocrat, while Citizen A is not so sure. In other words, the model suggests that citizen beliefs about the democratic or undemocratic nature of an incumbent's institutional reform agenda are critical. Even citizens who are ideologically sympathetic to an incumbent are likely to reject the incumbent if they believe that the institutional reforms the incumbent is pursuing are undemocratic:

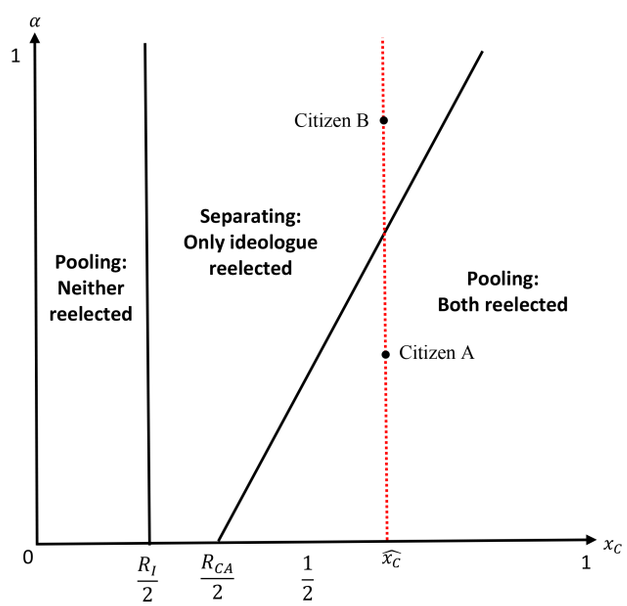

Figure 5. Interaction between ideology and uncertainty.

> **Empirical expectation.** Ceteris paribus, citizens are less likely to vote for a candidate as they become convinced that the institutional reforms the candidate is pursuing are undemocratic. This is also the case for citizens who are ideologically proximate to the incumbent.

We examine this expectation using an original survey experiment conducted in Poland in the spring of 2022—a particularly relevant setting for studying the potential for democratic backsliding. Consistent with our model, we find that citizens who interpret institutional reforms undertaken by an incumbent as nondemocratic are less likely to support the incumbent than citizens who are less certain of the motivations behind the reforms. This effect is robust to voters' pretreatment democratic commitments as well as to their ideology. In other words, our experiment highlights that support for closet autocrats is not just driven by ideological proximity but also by citizen uncertainty about incumbent intentions.

The context: Poland between 2015 and 2023

After a long period in opposition, the PiS won an absolute majority of legislative seats in the October 2015 parliamentary elections, forming the first single-party majority cabinet in Poland since 1989. Almost immediately, the government undertook a series of controversial institutional reforms, targeting in particular the Polish judiciary (Duncan and Macy 2020). The first of these arose out of a dispute between the outgoing parliamentary majority and the newly elected government regarding the appointment of justices to the Constitutional Tribunal. The PiS government passed legislation that forced the inclusion of its newly appointed justices, raised the required majority for declarations of unconstitutionality to two-thirds, and introduced the possibility of removing justices of the Tribunal by a majority vote of the legislature. Over the following years, the PiS government

embarked on systematic reform of the remaining parts of the judiciary. It changed the composition of the National Council of the Judiciary (Krajowa Rada Sadownictwa, KRS), the independent body that makes recommendations for judicial appointments (including to the Supreme Court) and initiates disciplinary action against members of the judiciary. Prior to the bill put forward by PiS, the KRS was made up exclusively of judges. The new PiS legislation dismissed the existing members and replaced them with political appointees.

Turning to the Supreme Court, legislation adopted in 2017 imposed a mandatory retirement age of 65 for the court's judges, with exemptions requiring presidential approval—a move that forced out 40% of sitting Supreme Court judges. The qualifications for holding a Supreme Court seat were lowered to a minimum of 12 years of experience in a regional court. Simultaneously, lower courts were reformed. The only exception to mandatory retirement above 65 was receiving an exemption from the Minister of Justice. Eventually, in December 2019, the PiS government adopted legislation that empowered the Disciplinary Chamber of the reformed Supreme Court (now with a comfortable majority of PiS appointed judges) to investigate and punish lower court judges for "political activities" and other misconduct—investigations that often targeted judges who objected to the PiS-led judicial reform.

Ideologue or "wolf in sheep's clothing"?

Condemnation of PiS' reform efforts was swift and significant. Many of the reforms were greeted with public protest, motivated by a concern that PiS was attempting to ensure a compliant judiciary that would enable it to undermine democratic competition and effective opposition. Similar concerns about "creeping authoritarianism" were raised by international observers, some Western governments, and—most significantly—the European Union, which launched formal proceedings to investigate whether the reforms violated Poland's obligations to the rule of law under EU treaties.

It is not difficult to see why critics of the PiS government suspected—in the language of our model—that the reform efforts might be the work of a closet autocrat. Tinkering with the judiciary would carry enormous payoffs for a closet autocrat, providing the government with resources to erect barriers for political opponents. For example, such control makes it easier to engage in political prosecutions, a common tactic in post-Soviet states.[6] The Supreme Court also plays a central role in Poland's party finance system. Because parties are only eligible for reimbursements of campaign expenditures after the party's finances have been declared "in order" by the Supreme Court, a government-controlled Supreme Court could potentially be used to reduce financial support for opposition parties. Finally, control of the courts more generally reduces the risk of judicial interference in the government's decisions.

While opponents of the reforms were alarmed by the perceived danger of creeping authoritarianism, PiS offered several explanations that aimed to assure its supporters that it had no designs to undermine the constitution. Perhaps the most salient of these took direct aim at the authoritarian past and argued that far from threatening democratic rule, the reforms were needed to eliminate the (undemocratic) power of "hold over" judges of the communist dictatorship. During the anniversary celebrations of the Gdansk Agreements, as crowds of protesters gathered and chanted "Constitution, Constitution!," President Duda defended the government's reform efforts with an explicit reference to these communist-era judges: "You are allowed to protest because I respect the constitution. But rest assured that a majority of people living on the coast feel threatened by the fact that there are justices on the benches of courts who sentenced members of the opposition during Martial Law." In other words, the government argued that the fact that the judiciary had been exempted from the lustration and decommunization process following the end of communist rule necessitated reforms aimed at curbing predemocratic influence within the judiciary (Nalepa 2010).

Moreover, the PiS government argued, there were practical reasons for the reform. Polish courts had been notoriously inefficient; commercial cases in particular faced delays of several years, contributing to lost foreign investment and slower economic growth. Increasing the accountability of judges, the government argued, was part of an effort to create a more favorable economic climate. In short, Polish citizens—particularly those sympathetic to the ideological positions of PiS—arguably faced genuine uncertainty about the ultimate motives behind the PiS-initiated reforms. This uncertainty was compounded when, in 2020, the PiS-packed Constitutional Court issued a decision significantly restricting access to abortion on constitutional grounds. The fact that this policy change—which had been a central plank of PiS' electoral commitments—was accomplished at the hands of the Supreme Court appeared to rationalize PiS's reform efforts in the eyes of some ideologically motivated voters.

6. In fact, the PiS government had considered putting Donald Tusk, the leader of the most influential opposition party, Civic Platform, on trial for treason. According to the Polish constitution, such a trial would take place before the State Tribunal (Trybunal Stanu), presided over by the chief justice of the Supreme Court, a position now controlled by PiS.

SURVEY AND EXPERIMENTAL EVIDENCE

In short, the 2015 to 2023 period in Poland offers a natural context for exploring the logic of our argument. The PiS government's reforms gave rise to fears of democratic backsliding, but there remained significant uncertainty, especially among voters who felt close to PiS, regarding the government's ultimate intentions. The aim of our survey experiment, conducted using a representative sample of 3,000 Polish voters in spring 2022, was to examine the empirical expectation implied by our model: Holding constant ideological preferences, voters become less likely to vote for an incumbent who engages in institutional reforms as they become more convinced that the reforms are motivated by undemocratic intentions.[7]

There was a significant complication we had to confront when constructing our survey. As is intuitive—and previous literature has established (Şaşmaz, Yagci, and Ziblatt 2022)—partisan bias may influence how voters perceive particular reforms. Those who are ideologically sympathetic to an incumbent are more likely to give the incumbent the benefit of the doubt about the intentions motivating a reform than voters who are ideologically opposed. For example, PiS supporters may interpret a reform proposal as democratic if they associate it with PiS and as undemocratic if they associate it with a party they are ideologically opposed to. Isolating the effect of citizen uncertainty about the intentions behind a reform requires a measure of how a voter interprets the intentions behind an institutional reform that is independent of the voter's ideological leanings and partisan preferences. At the same time, the reform needs to be plausible and resemble a real-world scenario. To address this challenge, we designed the survey to obtain a voter's evaluation of a generic, yet realistic, institutional reform devoid of partisan context before conducting our survey experiment. Specifically, respondents were presented with the following vignette:

> Electoral reforms have been initiated in several countries. They consist of introducing single-member districts, meaning that only one candidate can be elected from a given constituency—the one who receives the most votes. As a result, on the scale of the whole country, candidates supported by large parties have greater chances of being elected than candidates of small parties. Some believe that this solution strengthens democracy because it enables large parties to govern effectively. Others believe that this solution weakens democracy by making it difficult for smaller parties to participate in governance.

Critically, such a reform was never proposed by PiS, the potential "closet autocrat" in the Polish context. Using a reform actually proposed by PiS would increase the risk of partisan bias in evaluations. Moreover, the proposal has two key properties that can induce citizen uncertainty. On the one hand, it benefits the party that is capable of securing a majority of seats in the legislature. On the other hand, it can be defended as an effort to make government more efficient and accountable. Following the vignette, respondents were asked if the proposed institutional reform was, in their opinion, democratic or undemocratic. We asked respondents to place themselves on a scale running from 1 ("Reforms will make governments more accountable and effective") to 10 ("Reforms are an undemocratic way to weaken the opposition and allow the rulers to stay in power"). The resulting measure of a respondent's perception of the reform provides us with an assessment of how a respondent evaluates the democratic nature of an ambiguous reform that is independent of partisan influences. Reassuringly for our purposes, respondents are indeed divided in the assessment of the reform, as shown in figure 1 in appendix B, supporting the plausibility of uncertainty over the incumbent's intentions behind this proposal.

The conjoint experiment

Our conjoint experiment follows the protocols established in the literature (Graham and Svolik 2020; Jang et al. 2023; Svolik 2020). Respondents in a control and a treatment group are asked to choose between two hypothetical candidates. Each candidate is characterized by an ideological position and a proposal for an institutional reform. In the control group, the two candidates differ ideologically but propose the same reform. Thus, the support for each of the candidates in the control provides us with a baseline of the extent to which the choice between candidates can be attributed to the difference in ideology as perceived by the respondent. In the treatment group, respondents are presented with candidates with the same ideological positions as in the control. But in contrast to the control, the more conservative candidate proposes an arguably undemocratic reform. Again, respondents are asked to choose between the candidates. Tables 2 (control) and 3 (treatment) provide the candidate profiles presented to respondents.

As a first step, compare support for the two candidates across the treatment and control groups. This comparison,

7. Of our online sample, constructed with the help of the Center for Public Opinion Research, one of Poland's most reputable pollsters, 60% indicated interest in voting in the upcoming elections. The specifics of the survey are described in more detail in the appendix B.

Table 2. Conjoint Experiment Table: Control Group

Candidate A	Candidate B
[profession], [age]	[profession], [age]
Wants to strengthen relations with the European Union and limit the role of the Catholic Church in deciding about abortion rights	Is in favor of upholding Christian values, also in public life, and wants greater guarantees of Polish sovereignty within the European Union
Wants to popularize participation in elections by opening polling stations both on Saturday and Sunday of the election weekend (currently the presidential and the Sejm and Senate elections are held only on Sundays)	Wants to popularize participation in elections by opening polling stations both on Saturday and Sunday of the election weekend (currently the presidential and the Sejm and Senate elections are held only on Sundays)

which is the focus of analysis by Svolik and Graham, provides an estimate of how much voters are willing to punish undemocratic maneuvers. Since the candidates carry no party labels, any difference in respondent choice is driven by the institutional reform proposed and not partisan attachments. This comparison reveals levels of punishment in our survey experiment that are similar to those in appendix B.

Critically, evaluating our argument requires more than this simple comparison. The key issue for our account is whether the willingness to punish is a function of voter uncertainty about the intentions behind an incumbent's institutional reforms. Holding fixed voters' ideological commitments, we expect respondents who believe that reforms are democratic will be less likely to punish a candidate than respondents who interpret the reform as motivated by authoritarian ambitions. The former respondent corresponds to Citizen A in figure 5 (the pooling equilibrium), while the latter respondent corresponds to Citizen B in figure 5 (the separating equilibrium).

To evaluate these conditional expectations, we divide the respondents in our treatment and control groups based on their interpretation of the reform vignette offered earlier in the survey. Specifically, we separate respondents into four categories based on how suspicious they are of the intentions behind the vignette reform. In table 5 of appendix B, we show that random assignment resulted in covariate balance across these subgroups across the treatment and control groups.[8]

We are now in position to proceed with the analysis. Table 4 reports the fraction of respondents who choose Candidate B (ideologically, the more PiS-like candidate) across the treatment and control within each subgroup (defined by interpretation of the reform). Consistently with our expectations, as respondents view the vignette reform as more undemocratic, the less likely they are to support the potentially power-grabbing candidate in response to the treatment (i.e., comparing across control and treatment groups). Among those who view the reform as largely democratic (the first group), support for Candidate B drops from 45% to 40% (about a 13% reduction in support). In contrast, among those in high agreement that the reform is undemocratic, support drops from 26% to 16%, a reduction of approximately 40%. These results clearly suggest that the willingness to punish increases with citizens' beliefs that authoritarian motivation is behind the reform.

An alternative way to approach these data is to regress the decision to vote for Candidate B on the interaction between the treatment and the respondent's interpretation of the vignette reform, thus estimating the average marginal component effect of introducing the undemocratic reform, conditional on the respondents' interpretation of the vignette reform (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014).

The effects for the four categories of respondents are reported in figure 6, along with 95% confidence intervals, and provide clear support for our argument. Respondents who did not interpret the vignette reform as undemocratic (low and mid-low) are insensitive to the treatment: Introducing Candidate B who is prone to undemocratic moves does not produce significant differences relative to the purely ideological control. On the other hand, those voters who interpreted the vignette reform as undemocratic (mid-high and high) resolve the trade-off between ideology and democracy in a significantly different way: They are 10% to 12% less likely to vote for Candidate B.[9]

Correlational analysis

The advantage of the conjoint experiment we have just presented is that it confronts respondents with an actual choice

8. The "low" group is composed of those who responded that their belief about the reform being undemocratic is 1 to 3, "mid-low" is those who responded 4 to 5, "mid-high" responded 6 to 8, and "high" responded 9 to 10. We group respondents into four categories to maintain sufficient power.

9. The same findings—with an even more marked effect—hold when restricting the sample to voters who placed themselves on the right in the ideological spectrum, as depicted in figure 4 in the appendix.

Table 3. Conjoint Experiment Table: Treatment Group

Candidate A	Candidate B
[profession], [age]	[profession], [age]
Wants to strengthen relations with the European Union and limit the role of the Catholic Church in deciding about abortion rights	Is in favor of upholding Christian values, also in public life, and wants greater guarantees of Polish sovereignty within the European Union
Wants to popularize participation in elections by opening polling stations both on Saturday and Sunday of the election weekend (currently the presidential and the Sejm and Senate elections are held only on Sundays)	Wants the government to be able to extend the terms of the Sejm and Senate for a year or more in situations of exceptional state emergency and to postpone the election date without consulting other state authorities[11]

between concrete candidates. The downside is that this choice is disconnected from the Polish context. To strengthen confidence in the external validity of our results, we therefore turn to a correlational analysis to examine whether respondents' support for PiS (the potential closet autocrat) is conditioned by how respondents interpret our vignette reform. Specifically, we want to know whether, controlling for ideology as well as other relevant covariates, Polish citizens were less likely to vote for PiS as they became more suspicious that the vignette reform is motivated by undemocratic aims. To do this, we draw on our survey, which asked respondents a battery of standard questions including self-reported ideology and vote intention.

We estimate a logit model of the probability that a respondent intends to vote for PiS as a function of demographic variables, a number of covariates related to support for PiS, and the interaction between the respondent's ideology and his evaluation of the vignette reform:

$$y_i = \sigma(\alpha + \beta \text{ Ideological Self} - \text{Placement}_i + \gamma \text{ Reform Interpretation}_i + \delta \text{ Reform Interpretation}_i \times \text{Ideological Self} - \text{Placement}_i + \eta X_i + \theta_w + \epsilon_i),$$

where y_i is a dummy variable indicating whether respondent i intends to vote for PiS if elections were held on Sunday, the "Reform Interpretation" variable is our measure of how the voter interprets the reform vignette, θ_w are fixed effects for Poland's administrative units, and X_i are standard control variables.[10] We report the results in table 5.

Our primary interest is in the interactive effect of ideology and uncertainty regarding the aims of reform efforts. To show this interactive effect, figure 7 plots the predicted probabilities of voting for PiS as a function of the respondent's assessment that the reform is undemocratic, focusing on the most right-leaning voters in our survey (those self-placing in categories 5, 6, and 7 on the left–right scale and, consequently, ideologically closest to PiS), together with the distribution of their reform interpretation. The results provide clear evidence consistent with our expectations: Even among voters ideologically close to PiS, the probability of voting for this party decreases with skepticism regarding incumbents' reform intentions. As a voter at a given ideological position interprets the vignette reform as more undemocratic, she is less willing to cast her vote for PiS. For example, for those who place themselves at the right end of the ideological spectrum, the probability of voting for PiS decreases from 84% among those who believe the reform is largely democratic to 58% among those who regard it as largely undemocratic.

CONCLUSION

Our aim in this article has been to contribute to the emerging literature on democratic backsliding—an important phenomenon in a number of contemporary democracies. Existing literature has focused almost exclusively on the central role of polarization in the electorate in explaining why voters might be willing to support ideologically proximate parties and candidates, even if they have authoritarian tendencies (Graham and Svolik 2020; Svolik 2020). Others have examined polarization of elites and stress the importance of majoritarian political institutions that may allow governments to "shut out" opposition influence (Helmke et al. 2022; Howell and Wolton 2018). Our contribution in this article is to extend these explanations by focusing on the fact that democratic backsliding is a gradual process. Would-be autocrats typically reveal their

10. These include age, gender, education, size of the town of residence, employment status, religiosity, dissatisfaction with one's condition, and interest in politics. We also solicit voters' preferences for democracy using standard questions on democratic values from the World Values Survey and construct a z-score index. Details on how the index was put together and robustness checks can be found in appendix B.

11. We slightly vary the wording for half of the respondents presented with the treatment; see the appendix for details.

Table 4. Changes in Support for Candidate B for Introducing an Undemocratic Reform, Depending on Interpretation of the Vignette Reform

	% Choosing B			
Reform interpreted as undemocratic	Control	Treatment	Difference	% Change
Low agreement	.45	.40	−.05	−.13
Mid-low agreement	.35	.29	−.06	−.18
Mid-high agreement	.32	.22	−.10	−.31
High agreement	.26	.16	−.10	−.41

authoritarian intentions only over time. As a consequence, how voters interpret the actions taken by incumbent governments—and, in particular, whether those actions indicate authoritarian designs—becomes critical. Even voters who are opposed to authoritarianism may, unwittingly, promote backsliding. Moreover, voter uncertainty over the intentions of an incumbent can provide opportunities for would-be autocrats to "infiltrate" a democratic system as "wolves in sheep's clothing." By the time voters discover that those whom they have backed are closet autocrats, it may be too late (Luo and Przeworski 2023).

Put differently, our argument demonstrates that increasingly extreme ideological preferences by citizens matters for two distinct reasons. The first—an insight originally developed by Svolik (2020)—is that ideological extremity makes electoral punishment of the incumbent more difficult by making the opposition less attractive to potentially pivotal citizens. The second derives from the uncertainty that voters face about the incumbent's intentions in a dynamic setting: By making more extreme institutional reforms electorally viable, ideological extremity opens the door to strategic closet autocrats who may enter the political system because they see an opportunity to begin laying the groundwork for authoritarian power grabs while retaining power. Being uncertain about the incumbent's ultimate intentions, citizens—given sufficiently extreme preferences—may be willing to reelect an

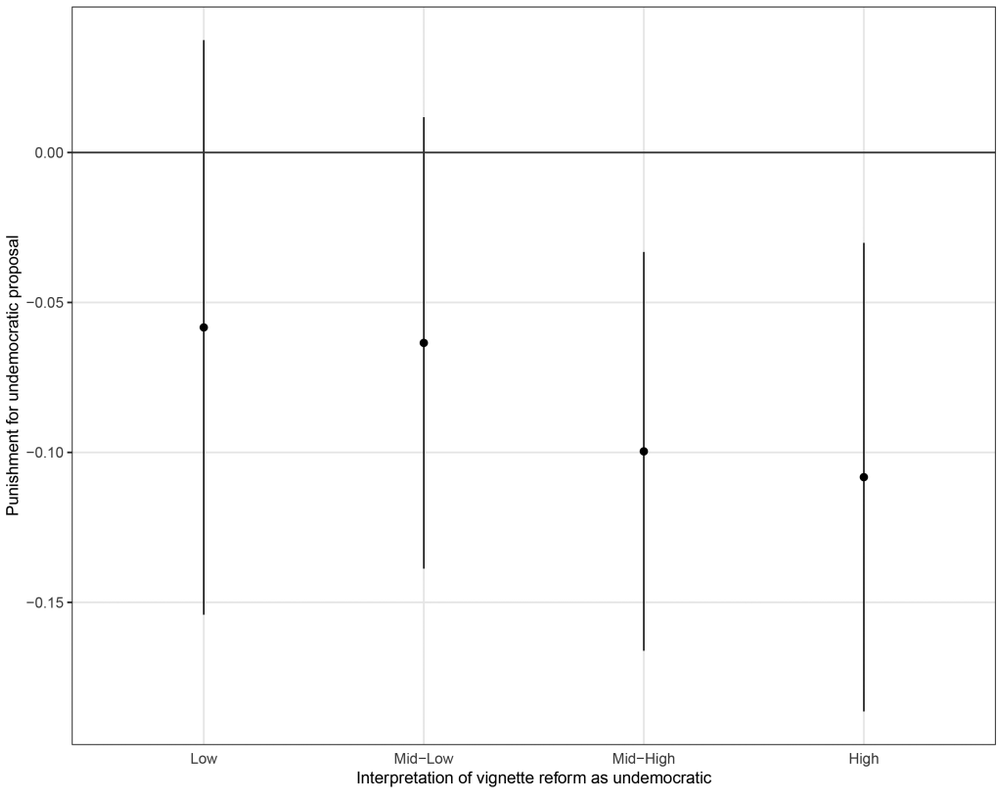

Figure 6. Conditional average marginal component effect, with 95% confidence intervals.

Table 5. Predictors of Voting for PiS if Elections Were Sunday: Logistic Regressions

	Dependent Variable		
	Would Vote for PiS if Elections Were Sunday		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Undemocratic interpretation	−.145***	−.129	−.143
	(.029)	(.104)	(.109)
Self-placement in left–right spectrum	.986***	.970***	.988***
	(.062)	(.131)	(.140)
Undemocratic interpretation × left–right		−.003	−.0004
		(.019)	(.020)
Expressed preferences for democracy	−.250***	−.236***	−.250***
	(.089)	(.088)	(.089)
Age	.023***	.023***	.023***
	(.006)	(.006)	(.006)
Education	−.189***	−.178***	−.189***
	(.029)	(.029)	(.029)
Town size	−.038	−.039	−.038
	(.037)	(.036)	(.037)
Unemployed	.115	.090	.115
	(.175)	(.172)	(.175)
Dissatisfaction with one's condition	−.393**	−.407**	−.393**
	(.185)	(.188)	(.185)
Gender	.218	.214	.218
	(.151)	(.149)	(.151)
Religiosity	.335***	.342***	.334***
	(.060)	(.059)	(.061)
Interest in politics	.143	.139	.143
	(.090)	(.088)	(.090)
Province fixed effect	yes	no	yes
Observations	1,879	1,879	1,879

* $p < .1$.
** $p < .05$.
*** $p < .01$.

incumbent only to discover afterward (and with regret) that the incumbent is in fact a closet autocrat.

As the model demonstrates, how extreme citizen preferences must be in order to give rise to these dynamics depends critically on voter beliefs about the nature of the incumbent and the extent to which voters are concerned to prevent authoritarianism. The less committed citizens are to democracy or the more they are convinced that the incumbent is merely an ideologue, the more likely it is that the process of democratic backsliding can begin even when citizen preferences are moderate.

This insight has clear, and potentially disturbing, substantive implications for the conditions under which the dynamics that are highlighted by our model are applicable. For example, consider long-established democracies. In such settings, citizens may be less attentive to the possibility that incumbent actions are motivated by authoritarian intentions. This may be particularly true when closet autocrats do not present themselves in the guise of newly created parties but instead emerge as a faction within an existing party with long-established democratic credentials. In such scenarios, citizens may—mistakenly—be too tolerant in dealing with an incumbent who is engaged in potentially undemocratic reforms. In other words, it may be exactly in established democracies, where citizens generally assume that incumbents are ideologues rather than closet autocrats, that a "wolf in sheep's clothing" may have an easier time coming to power. Along similar lines, the logic we have laid out also highlights that

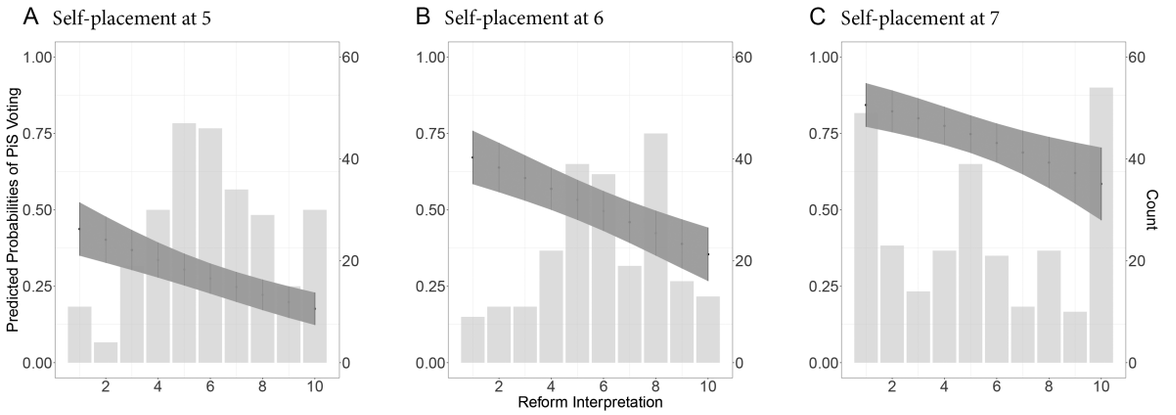

Figure 7. Predicted probabilities of PiS support for the three kinds of typical right-wing voters: very conservative (self-place at 7), moderately conservative (self-place at 6), and right of center (self-place at 5). The probabilities are calculated based on the model in column (2) of table 5, setting the control variables at their median values. The distribution of responses for the reform interpretation vignette for each group of self-placement is in light gray in the back.

moments of crisis, when democratic governments consider extraordinary institutional measures, may pose a special danger for democratic backsliding. It is precisely in such situations that citizens—believing that even democratically committed incumbents have reason to pursue extreme reforms—may become less vigilant and inadvertently empower a "wolf in sheep's clothing."

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The authors are grateful for comments from Peter Buisseret, Tiberiu Dragu, Anne Meng, Carlo Prato, Milan Svolik, and participants of the Conference in Formal Theory and Comparative Politics at Yale, the Seminar in European Politics at Stanford, and the Princeton Comparative Politics Colloquium.

REFERENCES

Aldrich, John H., and Rohde, David W. 2000. "The Consequences of Party Organization in the House: The Role of the Majority and Minority Parties in Conditional Party Government." In Jon R. Bond and Richard Fleisher, eds., *Polarized Politics: Congress and the President in a Partisan Era*. CQ Press, 31–72.

Bermeo, Nancy. 2016. "On Democratic Backsliding." *Journal of Democracy* 27 (1): 5–19.

Duncan, Allyson, and John Macy. 2020. "Judges on the March. The Collapse of Judicial Independence in Poland." *Judicature* 104:40–50.

Graham, Matthew H., and Milan W. Svolik. 2020. "Democracy in America? Partisanship, Polarization, and the Robustness of Support for Democracy in the United States." *American Political Science Review* 114 (2): 392–409.

Gratton, Gabriele, and Barton E. Lee. 2023. "Liberty, Security, and Accountability: The Rise and Fall of Illiberal Democracies." *The Review of Economic Studies* 91 (1): 340–71.

Grillo, Edoardo, and Carlo Prato. 2023. "Reference Points and Democratic Backsliding." *American Journal of Political Science* 67 (1): 71–88.

Hainmueller, Jens, Daniel J. Hopkins, and Teppei Yamamoto. 2014. "Causal Inference in Conjoint Analysis: Understanding Multidimensional Choices via Stated Preference Experiments." *Political Analysis* 22 (1): 1–30.

Helmke, Gretchen, Mary Kroeger, and Jack Paine. 2022. "Democracy by Deterrence: Norms, Constitutions, and Electoral Tilting." *American Journal of Political Science* 66 (2): 434–50.

Howell, William G., and Stephane Wolton. 2018. "The Politician's Province." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 13 (2): 119–46.

Jang, Austin, Filip Milačić, and Milan Svolik. 2023. "Who (Really) Supports Democracy? Experimental Evidence from Revealed Preference Measures." Unpublished manuscript.

Jenne, Erin K., and Cas Mudde. 2012. "Can Outsiders Help?" *Journal of Democracy* 23 (3): 147–55.

Levitsky, Steven, and Daniel Ziblatt. 2018. *How Democracies Die*. Crown.

Luo, Zhaotian, and Adam Przeworski. 2023. "Democracy and Its Vulnerabilities: Dynamics of Democratic Backsliding." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 18 (1): 105–130.

Lupu, Noam. 2014. "Brand Dilution and the Breakdown of Political Parties in Latin America." *World Politics* 66 (4): 561–602.

Nalepa, Monika. 2010. *Skeletons in the Closet: Transitional Justice in Post-communist Europe*. Cambridge University Press.

Şaşmaz, Aytuğ, Alper H. Yagci, and Daniel Ziblatt. 2022. "How Voters Respond to Presidential Assaults on Checks and Balances: Evidence from a Survey Experiment in Turkey." *Comparative Political Studies* 55 (11).

Sedelmeier, Ulrich. 2014. "Anchoring Democracy from Above? The European Union and Democratic Backsliding in Hungary and Romania After Accession." *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies* 52 (1): 105–21.

Serra, Gilles. 2012. "The Risk of Partyarchy and Democratic Backsliding: Mexico's 2007 Electoral Reform." *Taiwan Journal of Democracy* 8 (1): 31–56.

Stokes, Donald E. 1963. "Spatial Models of Party Competition." *American Political Science Review* 57 (2): 368–77.

Svolik, Milan. 2020. "When Polarization Trumps Civic Virtue: Partisan Conflict and the Subversion of Democracy by Incumbents." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 15:3–31.

Voeten, Erik. 2016. "Are People Really Turning Away from Democracy?" Preprint, SSRN, December 8. https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.2882878.

Waldner, David, and Ellen Lust. 2018. "Unwelcome Change: Coming to Terms with Democratic Backsliding." *Annual Review of Political Science* 21:93–113.